

RURAL ROAD (R2) OR RURAL LANE (R3)?

A classification question for the Planning Board – Article 3, Thoroughfares

THE QUESTION

Article 3 gives every existing road in Newcastle a Thoroughfare Type. Two rural Types sit next to each other on the scale:

- **R2 Rural Road** – the standard rural road: two lanes, an 18 ft traveled way, a 40 ft right-of-way.
- **R3 Rural Lane** – the narrowest Road Type: a single shared surface, a 12 ft traveled way, a 33 ft right-of-way, gravel acceptable. The Code describes it as the designation for low-volume ways “generally under 400 [vehicles] per day” and for narrow historic two-rod rights-of-way.

Today **four** segments are classified R3 – Camp Road, Desperado Lane, Fern Birch Lane, and Hawthorn Road, the small private lanes running off Route 1. Every other small rural way in Town, including many that are shorter, is classified R2.

The question for the Board: should R3 apply more broadly – and if so, on what test?

WHY THE ANSWER MATTERS

R3 is the *lighter* standard. This is not a technicality; it decides how much work a property owner must do if a lane is ever improved.

	R2 Rural Road	R3 Rural Lane
Right-of-way (build to)	40 ft	33 ft
Traveled way (build to)	18 ft, two 9 ft lanes	12 ft, one shared lane
Design speed	25 mph	15 mph
Curb return radius	25 ft	15 ft
Surface	Paved or gravel	Gravel
Maximum grade	12%	12%
Sight distance	Per Table 3.2	Per Table 3.2

The safety standards – sight distance, maximum grade, drainage – are identical. What differs is width and surface.

This connects directly to the concern residents raised about “road stubs.” Under the new Section 7.F, a driveway that grows to serve more than two dwellings must be improved to the Type assigned to it. If a small lane is classified R2, that improvement means an 18 ft traveled way in a 40 ft right-of-way. If it is classified R3, it means a 12 ft shared gravel surface in a 33 ft right-of-way. **Classifying these lanes correctly as R3 substantially reduces what a future owner would have to build.**

WHAT IS ON THE TABLE

There are **122** dead-end segments currently classified R2. Of those, **61** are 1,000 ft or shorter – the range in which a “lane” reading is plausible. The four existing R3 segments run 303 ft, 444 ft, 508 ft, and 593 ft.

If the Board sets a length test, the number of segments that would move from R2 to R3 is:

If the test is ...	Private ways only	All owners
300 ft or less	8	9
400 ft or less	19	21
500 ft or less	29	32
600 ft or less	31	34
800 ft or less	45	49
1,000 ft or less	54	61

OPTIONS

Option 1 – Leave R3 as it is. R3 remains the four lanes off Route 1. Simple, but it leaves an inconsistency that is visible on the map: Eden Lane is 277 ft, shorter than Camp Road at 303 ft, yet Eden Lane is a Rural Road and Camp Road is a Rural Lane. The only thing separating them is which road they connect to.

Option 2 – A length test. Any private dead-end way at or under the chosen length becomes R3. Objective, easy to apply, and easy for a property owner to check. Its weakness is that length is only a rough stand-in for how much traffic a way actually carries.

Option 3 – A use test. R3's own definition is about traffic volume, not length. The Board could instead classify by the number of dwellings a way serves – for example, a private way serving four or fewer dwellings is R3. This matches the Code's language most closely, but the Town does not currently hold dwellings-served counts for each way; they would have to be gathered.

Option 4 – Case by case. The Board reviews the list below and names individual roads.

RECOMMENDATION

Option 2, with the test set at 600 ft or less for private dead-end ways – 31 segments.

The reasons: it is consistent with the four lanes already classified R3, the longest of which is 593 ft; it captures the ways that function today as shared driveways; it is objective, so a property owner can determine the answer without asking anyone; and because R3 is the lighter standard, it reduces rather than increases the obligation on rural landowners.

The Board should know that length is a proxy. A 900 ft lane serving three houses carries no more traffic than a 400 ft lane serving three houses. If the Board prefers the more accurate test, Option 3 is the better planning answer and the Town can gather the counts.

Whatever the Board decides is recorded permanently and carries forward automatically when the Town's district mapping is finalized – no decision has to be made twice.

ALSO NOTICED

Three entries in the road data look like mapping artifacts rather than real roads. They do not affect the question above, but the Board may wish to have them corrected:

- **Station Road** carries an 11-foot segment with no connection at either end.
- **Kavanagh Road** and **Woods Island Road** have no ownership category recorded.

THE FULL LIST

Every dead-end road segment currently classified **R2 Rural Road** at 1,000 ft or less, shortest first. The four segments already classified R3 are not listed. A further 61 R2 dead-end segments are longer than 1,000 ft and are not proposed for change under any option.

Length (ft)	Road	Ownership	District(s)	Connects to
11	Station Road	Town Way	D1	end
277	Eden Lane	Private	D1	Sheepscot Road
283	Mechanics Way	Private	D1	Station Road
287	Mandys Way	Private	D1	North Newcastle Road
291	Cherry Lane	Private	D1	River Road
291	Marsh View Lane	Private	D1	Station Road
291	Phils Hill Road	Private	D1	Jones Woods Road
295	Gastaldo Farm Road	Private	D2	Academy Hill
295	Dickenson Road	Private	D1	North Newcastle Road
303	East Branch Road	Private	D1	The Kings Highway

Length (ft)	Road	Ownership	District(s)	Connects to
304	Deer Meadow Road	Private	D1	end
307	Middle Way	Private	SD-Campus	Academy Hill
314	Hodkins Road	Private	D1	River Road
319	Cottril Road	Private	D4	Academy Hill
341	Birch Road	Private	D1	Ridge Road
350	Hall Street	Private	D1, D5	Academy Hill
358	Swallow Hill Road	Private	D1, SD-Rural Highway	River Road
362	Elm Road	Private	D1	Ridge Road
377	Bartlet Neck Road	Private	D1	end
383	Bay View Road	Private	SD-Highway Commercial	end
383	Old Austin Road	Town Way	SD-Conservation	Mills Road
405	Meadow Ridge Lane	Private	D1	Jones Woods Road
421	Blueberry Hill Road	Private	D1	Bunker Hill Road
421	Jackies Way	Private	D1	West Hamlet Road
422	Maple Lane	Private	D1	Bunker Hill Road
449	Hillcrest Road	Town Way	D1	Academy Hill / East Old County Road
458	Morgan Brook Lane	Private	D1	Jones Woods Road
461	Granite Point Road	Private	D1	Ridge Road
462	Doe Run	Private	D1	Lewis Hill Road
478	Depot Street	Private	D1	Academy Hill
489	Bay View Road	Private	SD-Highway Commercial	Academy Hill
495	Ledge Hill Crossing	Private	SD-Highway Commercial, D1	Sheepscot Road
517	Alder Shore Road	Private	D1	end
592	Chandler Way	Private	D1, D6	end
613	Pine Ledge Drive	Private	D1	West Old County Road
620	Hillside Road	Town Way	D1	Jones Woods Road
651	Rocky Ledge Road	Private	D1	North Newcastle Road
652	Strix Hill Road	Private	D1	Jones Woods Road
657	Oyster Lane	Private	D1	River Road
677	Curlewis Lane	Private	D1	North Newcastle Road
689	High View Road	Private	D1	Bunker Hill Road
694	Paradise Road	Private	D1	North Newcastle Road
699	Osprey Point Road	Private	SD-Conservation, D1	Route 1
716	Layden Lane	Private	D1	Sheepscot Road
723	East View Road	Private	D2, D1, SD-Highway Commercial	Mills Road
734	Barrol Point Road	Private	D1	Main Street / River Road
758	Deer Meadow Road	Private	D1	Ridge Road
764	Thistle Way	Private	D1	Bunker Hill Road
796	Stony Ridge Lane	Private	D1, D5	West Old County Road
809	Briarwood Lane	Private	D1	Station Road

Length (ft)	Road	Ownership	District(s)	Connects to
825	Waterview Lane	Private	D1	River Road
844	Cottage Road	Private	D1	end
847	High Ground Road	Town Way	D1	Jones Woods Road
867	Schraft Road	Private	D1	River Road
893	Nob Hill Road	Private	D1	end
895	Robinson Road	Town Way	D1, SD-Rural Highway	River Road
902	Cole Cabin Road	Private	D2	Academy Hill
916	Grace Lily Lane	Private	D1	Pond Road
945	Kiln Road	Private	D1	River Road
953	Woods Island Road	(not recorded)	D1, SD-Civic, SD-Rural Highway	Route 1
987	Sheepscott River Way	Private	D1	end